Shinde—as a factor that can in turn limit Ajit's powers too. Indicating it will be far from a carte blanche for the latter, the MLA says Ajit will have to take along his colleagues from the BJP and Sena. "Ajit and his faction have joined us in a certain set of circumstances," he says, citing the cases with the central investigation agencies. "The Ajit Pawar in the BJP-led regime will be different from the one in the MVA regime. How these power equations play out will also depend on Shinde, as it is the CM who is the head of the government and he must put his foot down where he should," he explains.

The idea of his diminution gives solace to Thackeray's Sena. "It's evident the BJP has realised that Shinde can't run the state. Its idea of propping him up as a Maratha face too seems to have come a cropper. They will now portray Ajit Pawar as their Maratha face," says a loyalist source. As a cautionary note, he also cites the BJP's appropriative appetite, saying it may prevail upon both rebel factions to merge with the BJP after the Lok Sabha election.

The Sena and NCP factions have tried to underplay reports of differences. "When a new friend comes along, some adjustments must be made. There will be no injustice on anyone," said Shinde. On past complaints about Ajit's conduct as deputy CM and finance minister in the MVA, Shinde added: "I was not the CM then. Now, I am the CM and will ensure that all MLAs get equitable justice." The NCP's Hasan Mushrif, the new medical education minister, however, denied Ajit had done any *"anyay"* (injustice) on MVA constituents.

On his part, Fadnavis calls the relationship with Shinde an "emotional alliance"—harking back to the old BJP-Sena ties—while designating the one with Ajit Pawar as a "political friendship" that was part of the BJP's *"kootneeti"* or realpolitik. As Congress leader Balasaheb Thorat points out, the Maharashtra government is a unique one—it has a CM, a deputy CM who was once a CM and a deputy CM who wants to be a CM! A 'tango for three' that will determine Shinde's fate. ■




**IN A TIGHT SPOT**
Selected candidates of the patwari recruitment test protesting in Bhopal

ANI

MADHYA PRADESH

# VYAPAM 2.0?

By Rahul Noronha

The recently announced results of a recruitment exam in Madhya Pradesh have rocked the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s boat just months ahead of the state assembly election. A series of unusual 'coincidences' have come to light after the results, prompting the opposition Congress to attack the party nationally. What has made matters worse is the fact that the agency that conducted the test is none other than Vyapam, the subject of the multi-crore jobs scandal that shook the state in 2013. Though it has been renamed the 'Employees Selection Board' (ESB) now, the latest controversy has evoked uneasy memories again.

On June 30, the ESB declared the results for its Group 2 sub-group 4 exam, a general test held to recruit 8,617 candidates, which includes 3,555 patwaris, the all-powerful revenue officials who manage land records in rural areas. A total of 1.3 million candidates had applied for the exam, of which around 950,000 took the test. A fortnight later, once answer papers and documents were made available under a transparency initiative, the National Educated Youth Union (NEYU), a group that keeps a watch on recruitments, blew the whistle. Of the 10 toppers, while eight are from the Gwalior-Chambal region, seven wrote their exam from Gwalior's NRI College of Engineering and Management, which is owned by the BJP's Bhind MLA Sanjeev Kushwaha, said Ranjeet Kisanwanshi, NEYU core committee member. The Congress also pointed out that though the toppers signed their exam sheets in Hindi, they scored well in the English section. Another issue that raised eye-